

English around the world

ENGLISH IS USED THROUGHOUT THE WORLD, BUT NOT ALWAYS IN THE SAME WAY.

Many countries throughout the world use the English language, but the way it's used—especially spoken—can differ hugely between regions, even within the same country.

Spread the word

The English language can be traced back to a combination of Anglo-Saxon dialects more than 1,500 years old. It started to spread around the world from the 1600s onward, when the British began to explore and colonize, taking their language with them. Today, the English language continues to grow in popularity, especially in Southeast and eastern Asia, where English is seen as the preferred language for business and trade with Western countries.

1. In the Caribbean and Canada, historical links with the UK compete with geographical, cultural, and economic ties with the United States, so their language reflects both British and American forms of English.

2. Most of South America speaks Spanish or Portuguese because Spain and Portugal once had empires there. However, in a few countries in Central and South America—such as Guyana, which achieved independence from Great Britain in 1966—the official language is English.



Spot the differences

After the English language was taken to North America, the spelling of certain words started to change. Published in 1828, *An American Dictionary of the English Language* established spellings such as *center* and *color* (instead of the British spellings *centre* and *colour*), creating a broader acceptance of American and British English as two distinct entities. These variations in spelling still exist today.

▷ Spelling and punctuation

British and American English use different spellings and punctuation. For example, verbs such as *criticise* are spelled with an *s* in British English but a *z* in American English. American English often uses longer dashes and more commas in a list than British English.

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British version

American version

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